

BEAKED WHALES

The Ziphiidae are found in the open ocean, typically in small groups that congregate around underwater canyons. They feed near the sea floor, diving for an hour or more. Their facial beak usually has one or two pairs of teeth, which are for display only – food is simply sucked in. Because of their remote habitat and ability to dive deep, few of the 22 species in the family are familiar; some have never been sighted alive.



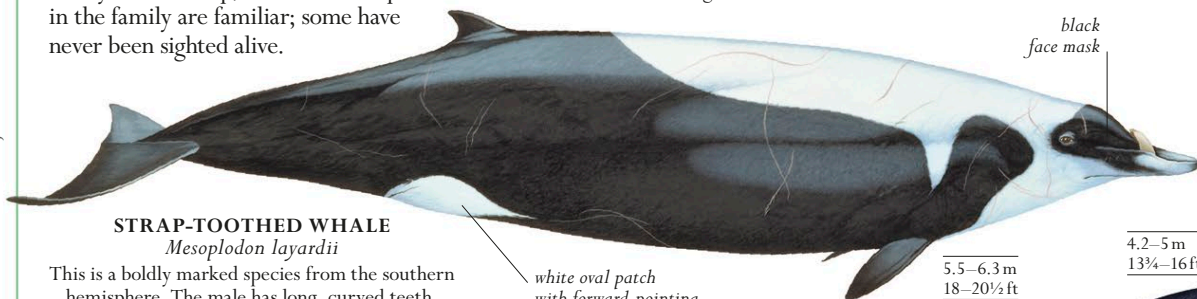
GRAY'S BEAKED WHALE
Mesoplodon grayi

Found throughout the southern hemisphere, this is one of the few beaked whales with numerous teeth. Its long, slender beak is often whitish.



BLAINVILLE'S BEAKED WHALE
Mesoplodon densirostris

An arched lower jaw and flattened forehead make this widespread species one of the more easily recognized beaked whales.



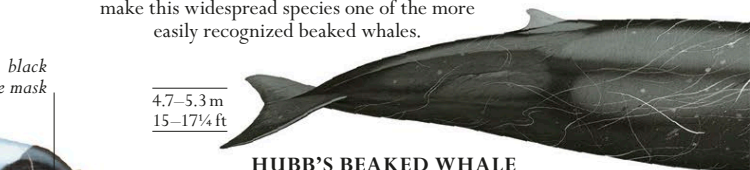
STRAP-TOOTHED WHALE
Mesoplodon layardii

This is a boldly marked species from the southern hemisphere. The male has long, curved teeth, which can meet over the upper jaw.



GINKGO-TOOTHED BEAKED WHALE
Mesoplodon ginkgodens

This species is known mainly from strandings (washing ashore on beaches) in the Pacific and Indian oceans. The males have distinctively broad, triangular teeth.



HUBB'S BEAKED WHALE
Mesoplodon carlhubbsi

Presumed to inhabit the North Pacific, but rarely seen, this species has white patches on its beak and head. The male has two prominent teeth.

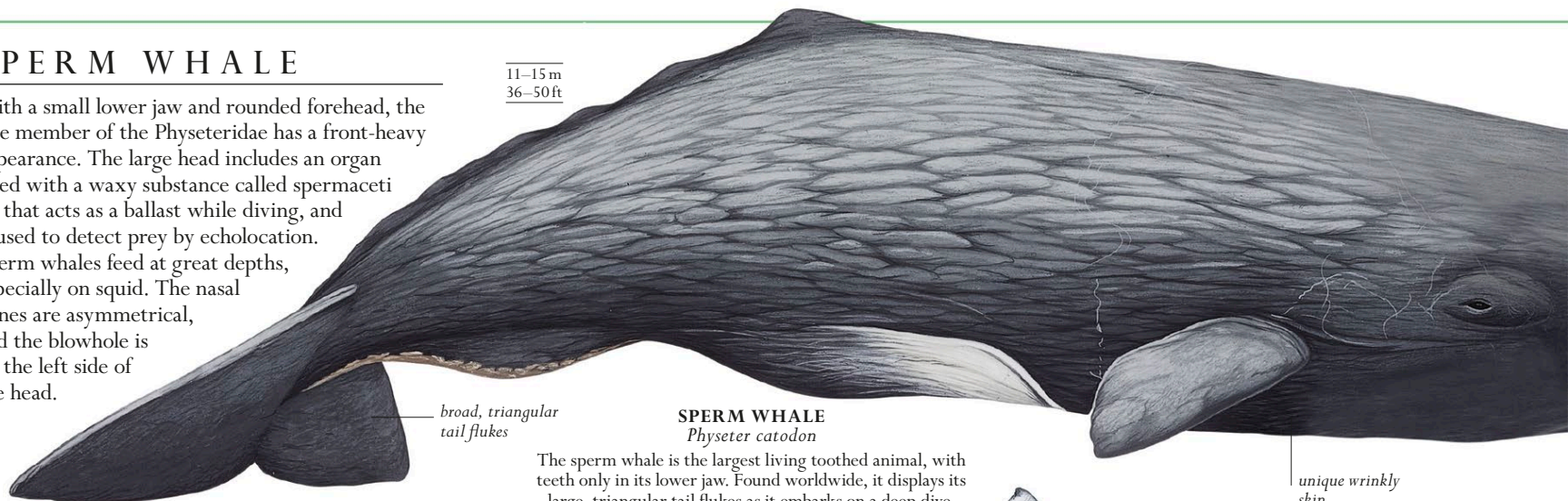


GERVAIS' BEAKED WHALE
Mesoplodon europaeus

This slender whale is seen most often around the Canary Islands in the Atlantic Ocean. The male's teeth are small and at the tip of the beak.

SPERM WHALE

With a small lower jaw and rounded forehead, the sole member of the Physeteridae has a front-heavy appearance. The large head includes an organ filled with a waxy substance called spermaceti oil that acts as a ballast while diving, and is used to detect prey by echolocation. Sperm whales feed at great depths, especially on squid. The nasal bones are asymmetrical, and the blowhole is on the left side of the head.

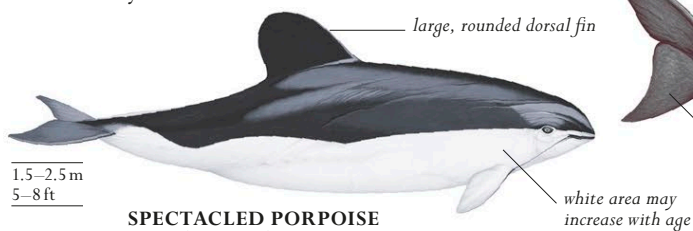


SPERM WHALE
Physeter catodon

The sperm whale is the largest living toothed animal, with teeth only in its lower jaw. Found worldwide, it displays its large, triangular tail flukes as it embarks on a deep dive.

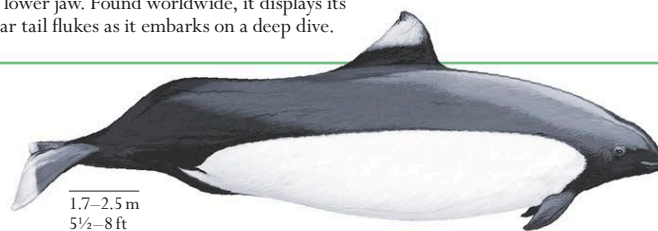
PORPOISES

Generally smaller but stouter than dolphins, the Phocoenidae have a small, rounded head and blunt jaws. The dorsal fin is triangular rather than curved. Most distinctively, porpoises have flattened, spade-shaped teeth. Active predators of fish, squid, and crustaceans, porpoises use sound to find prey and communicate. The seven species occur mainly in shallow coastal waters.



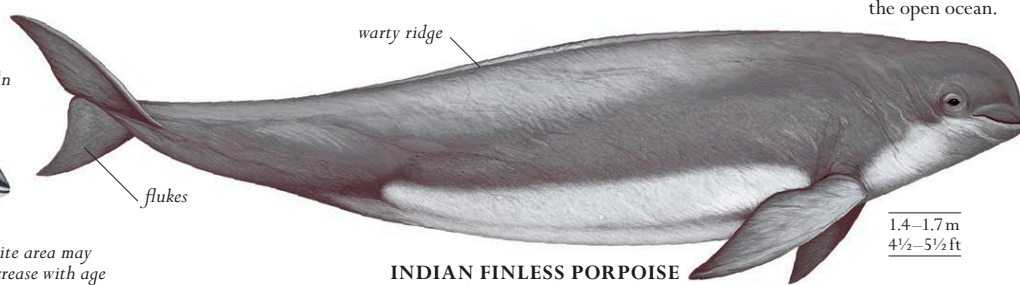
SPECTACLED PORPOISE
Phocoena dioptrica

Although rarely seen in its sub-Antarctic range, this species is readily recognized by its sharply demarcated colours. The upper blue-black skin makes it difficult to see from above.



DALL'S PORPOISE
Phocoenoides dalli

This highly active porpoise from the North Pacific has a stout, bicoloured body and a small head. It prefers the open ocean.



INDIAN FINLESS PORPOISE
Neophocaena phocaenoides

Found throughout Asian coastal waters, including a freshwater population in China, this porpoise has a low warty ridge instead of a dorsal fin.